



COURAGEOUS CONVERSATIONS

THE LEADERSHIP SKILL THAT CREATES CONNECTION

MARNI BLYTHE

KEYNOTE SPEAKER

**AUTHOR OF BESTSELLER "CULTURE CATALYST"
FRACTIONAL COO/CMO/INTEGRATOR**





**I WANT YOU TO CLOSE YOUR EYES
FOR JUST A MOMENT.**







**IS THERE A CONVERSATION YOU'VE
BEEN PUTTING OFF?**



A close-up photograph of a smooth, white, oval-shaped stone with the word "Courage" engraved in a dark, serif font. The stone is surrounded by numerous dark, smooth, rounded stones of various shades of black and dark brown. The lighting is dramatic, highlighting the white stone against the dark background.

Courage

**EVERY LEADER CAN NAVIGATE
CONFLICT WITH COURAGE!**

WHAT IS A CRITICAL CONVERSATION?

A critical conversation is a high-stakes, high-emotions discussion that directly impacts relationships, performance, trust, or outcomes





WHAT DO YOU THINK ARE EXAMPLES OF THE MOST CRITICAL CONVERSATIONS?

- Giving honest feedback to a partner, associate, or team member
- Addressing performance issues
- Inappropriate behavior
- Pay-related conversations
- Termination
- Personal hygiene
- Unhappy patients
- Workplace conflict
- Career development

RATE YOURSELF

1

**I avoid them
at all costs.**

(I dread these
conversations and usually
stay silent or withdraw.)

3

**I struggle,
but I try.**

(I'm uncomfortable and
often stumble, but I'm
making the effort.)

5

**I've made
progress.**

(I've improved and feel
more confident, but I still
have work to do.)

8

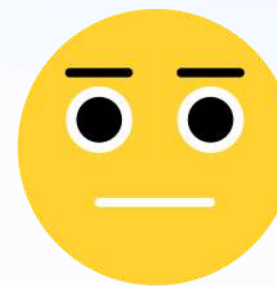
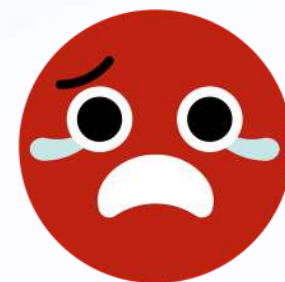
**I'm strong in
this area.**

(I handle most tough
conversations well, and I
keep sharpening my skills.)

10

**I lead with clarity
and calm.**

(I navigate difficult
conversations with
confidence, empathy, and
consistency.)





1

TENSION IS A CLUE





THE ACT FRAMEWORK



A

ACKNOWLEDGE
THE SIGNAL



C

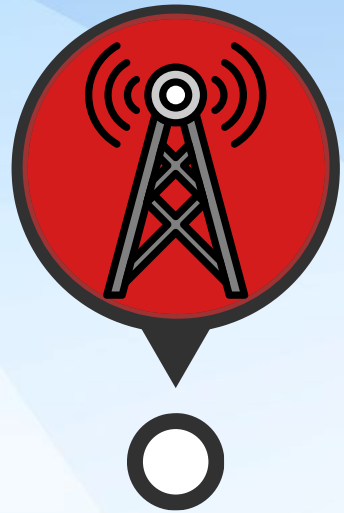
CHECK
YOURSELF



T

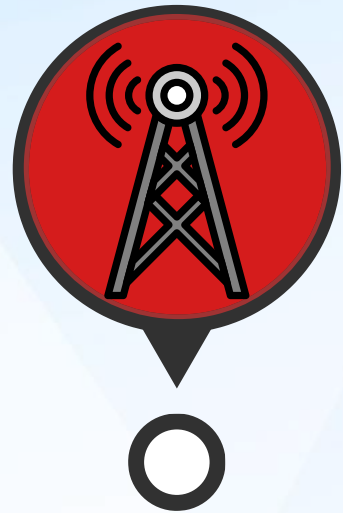
TAKE INTENTIONAL
ACTION

THE ACT FRAMEWORK



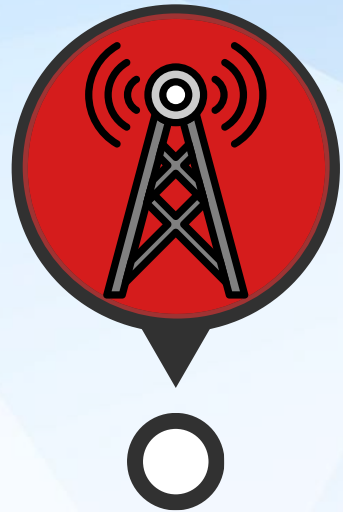
**TAKE IN THE INFORMATION WITH
NEUTRALITY. PRACTICE, “ISN’T
THAT INTERESTING...”**

THE ACT FRAMEWORK



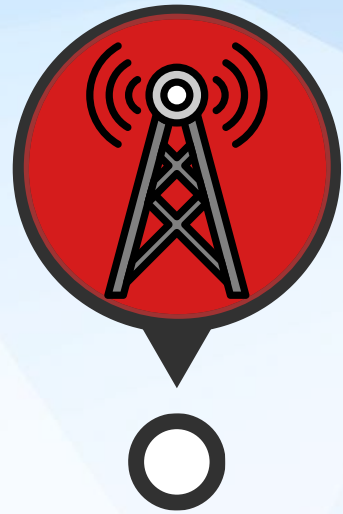
DOES THIS NEED TO BE ADDRESSED?

THE ACT FRAMEWORK



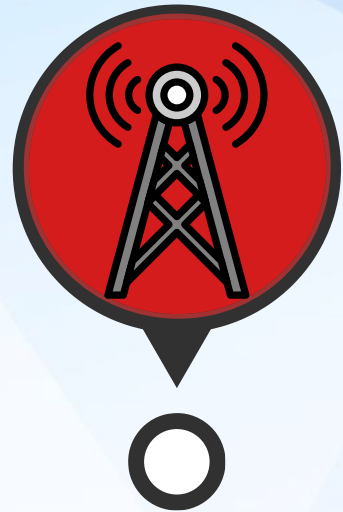
IS IT MINE TO ADDRESS?

THE ACT FRAMEWORK



**WHAT COULD HAPPEN IF IT REMAINS
UNRESOLVED?**

THE ACT FRAMEWORK



**DO I NEED TO FACILITATE A
CONVERSATION BETWEEN TEAM
MEMBERS?**

2

CHECK YOUR VIEW

THE ACT FRAMEWORK



C

CHECK
YOURSELF

SELF AWARENESS



**IT'S KNOWING WHAT'S
GOING ON INSIDE YOU
AND HOW THAT AFFECTS
WHAT'S HAPPENING
AROUND YOU.**

Stimulus



Response

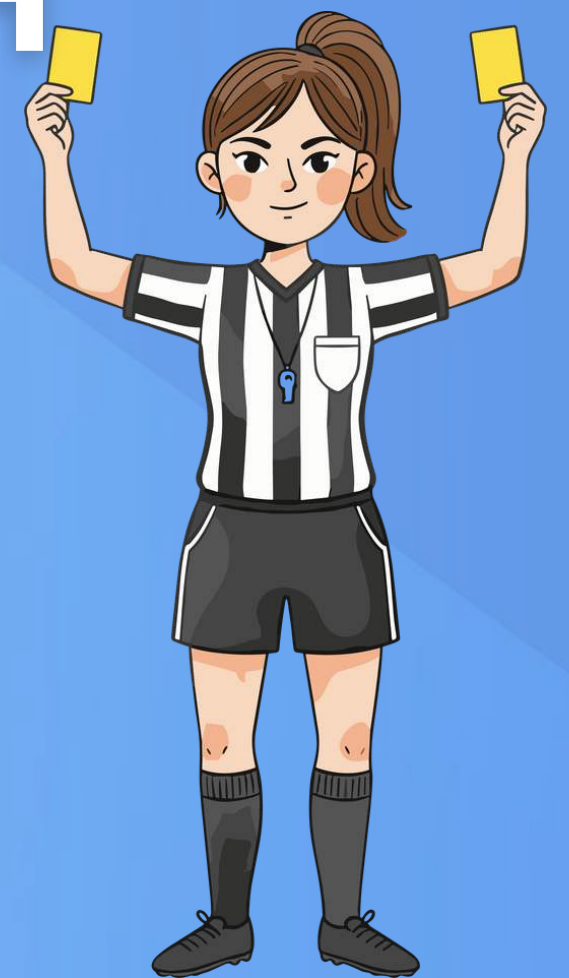
SPACE

Viktor Frankl

**“MY NAME IS MARNI. I AM AN
EMPATH. ARE YOU?”**



**“THE MOMENT I STARTED
LEANING IN ONE DIRECTION, I
STOPPED BEING A LEADER AND
STARTED BEING A REFEREE WITH
A FAVORITE.”**





**“RECOGNIZE WHAT
IS HAPPENING
WITHIN YOU.”**



**“BEFORE YOU WALK INTO THE ROOM,
TAKE A BREATH.
NAME WHAT YOU’RE FEELING.
NOTICE WHAT YOU’RE CARRYING.
THEN MAKE A CHOICE ABOUT HOW
YOU WANT TO SHOW UP.”**



3

CHOOSE WHAT TO DO

THE ACT FRAMEWORK



T

TAKE INTENTIONAL
ACTION

**THAT DECISION IS: DO I AVOID
THIS, CONFRONT THIS NOW,
OR POSTPONE THIS
STRATEGICALLY?**



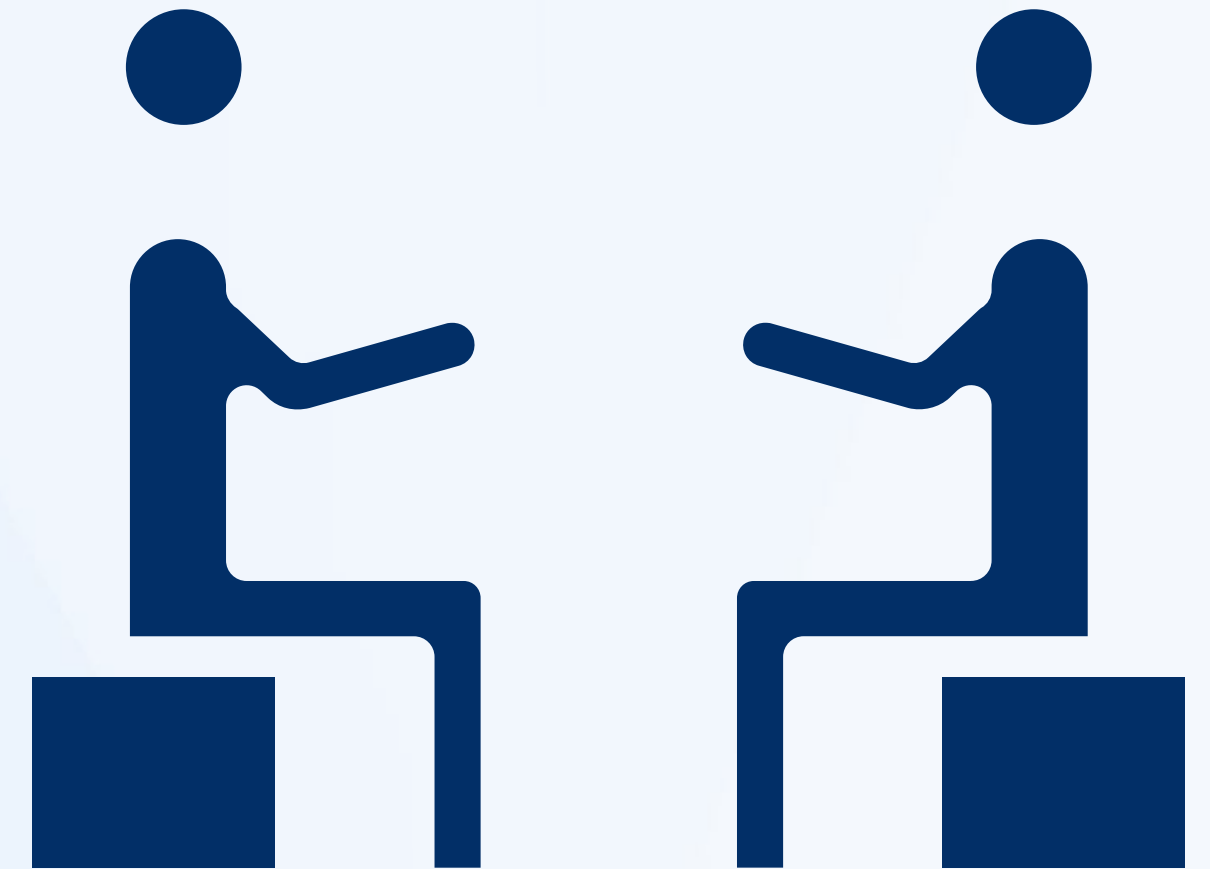
AVOID?

Avoidance is the easiest to do and, sadly, the most popular, although not always the correct choice. Many of us struggle to know what to say, and we panic and say nothing in the midst of the conflict.



CONFRONT?

Are there times when you shouldn't wait? Absolutely. Sometimes, postponing sends the wrong message—it gives silent permission for bad behavior.



POSTPONE?

*“Behavior not addressed
will not change”*

POSTPONED

ROCK
CAROL

Bec



ONCE YOU'VE USED ACT AND
DECIDED THE CONVERSATION
NEEDS TO HAPPEN, THE NEXT
QUESTION IS:

“WHAT DO I ACTUALLY SAY?”

THAT'S WHERE PREPARATION +
CORE COMES IN.

SAMPLE DIALOGUE USING CORE + FEEDBACK



CONTEXT

"Reid, thanks for taking a few minutes. I want to talk about how we are communicating and work on best practices so we can work really well together."

👉 **Pause:** "Can we talk about what's been happening?"

1



OBSERVATION

"Over the last few weeks, I've noticed that you've come out of the huddle several times and told me what you needed me to do without asking whether I was available or explaining what support you needed."

👉 **Pause:** "Can you help me understand what's going on?"
(Active Listening)

2



RESULT

"When that happens, I feel frustrated and it creates tension between us. It makes it harder for us to communicate and work well together."

👉 **Check-in:** "How are you experiencing our communication?"
(Active Listening)

3



EXPECTATIONS

"Going forward, I'd like you to ask for my help instead of telling me what to do, and explain what you need from me."

👉 **Pause:** "What do you need from me, and what can we agree to do differently?"
(Active Listening)

4

TENSION IS A CLUE.

CHECK YOUR VIEW.

CHOOSE WHAT TO DO.





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and enter this code when prompted

MARNI

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**“COURAGEOUS
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